The female reproductive system consists of a pair of **ovaries** lying in the 13th segment. Each ovary has finger like projections which contain ova in linear series. Ovarian funnels are present beneath the ovaries which continue into the **oviducts**. They open as a pair of genital apertures on the ventral side of the 14th segment. **Spermathecae** or **seminal receptacles** are three pairs lying in segments 7th, 8th and 9th, opening to the exterior on the ventral side between 6th & 7th, 7th & 8th and 8th & 9th segments. They receive spermatozoa from the partner and store during copulation.

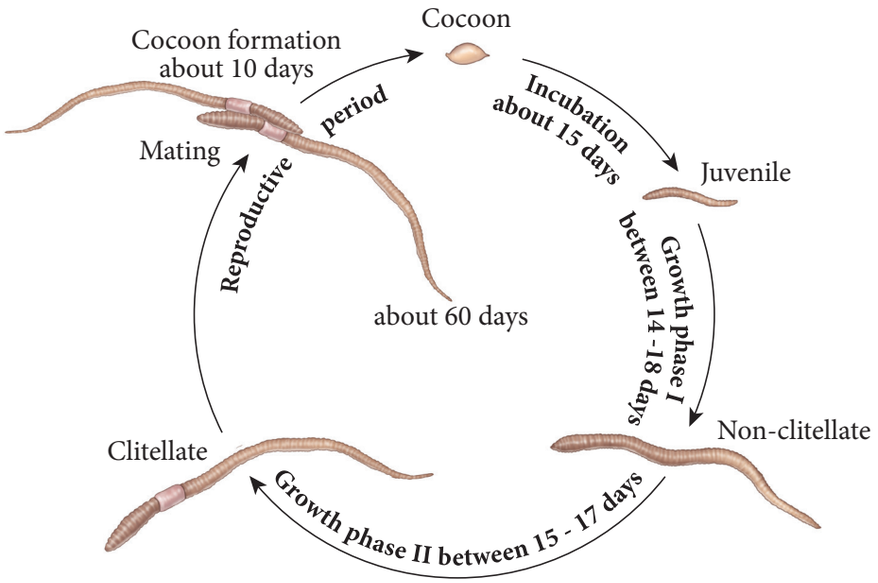


Figure 4.7 Life cycle of *Lampito mauritii*

Regeneration



Earthworms have most of their important organ in the first 20 segments. If earthworm gets cut after the 20th segment, the anterior half can regenerate, while the posterior half shall disintegrate after some time.

A mutual exchange of sperms occurs between two worms during mating. One worm has to find another worm and they mate juxtaposing opposite gonadal openings, exchanging the sperms. Mature egg cells in the nutritive fluid are deposited in the cocoons produced by the gland cells of the clitellum which also collects the partner's sperms from the spermthecae. Fertilization and development occurs within the cocoons, which are deposited in the soil. After about 2 – 3 weeks, each cocoon produces baby earthworms. Development is direct and no larva is formed during development.

Life cycle

Lampito mauritii begins its life cycle, from the fertilized eggs. The eggs are held in a protective cocoon. These cocoons have an incubation period of about 14- 18 days after which they hatch to release **juveniles** (Figure 4.7). The juveniles undergo changes into **non-clitellate** forms in phase – I after about 15 days, which then develops a clitellum, called the **clitellate** at the end of the growth phase – II taking 15 - 17 days to complete. During the reproductive stage, earthworms copulate, and later shed their cocoons in the soil after about 10 days. The life cycle of *Lampito mauritii* takes about 60 days to complete.

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